

WEEK 3 LESSON GUIDE

**STICK
TOGETHER**

BIG IDEA

Good friends are worth fighting for.

BIBLE

Proverbs 27:17; Acts 15:36–41;
Psalm 51:10

ABOUT THIS WEEK

Strong friendships form through journeys that face storms and disagreements, but they're worth holding onto. This week, we'll see how Paul and Barnabas's conflict led them down different paths, yet later repair showed the value of sticking together... reminding us **good friends are worth fighting for.**

WHAT? What are we talking about?



See the
Accessibility Hacks

ACTIVITY | Friendly Face-Off

- Welcome back to *Stick Together*, where we're talking about the sometimes perilous adventure that is friendship. Let's put a few really good friendships to the test today.
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** For this activity, you'll need jungle-themed props (like [fake tropical plants](#), [jungle-themed props](#), and [safari hats](#)) and a timer. Decorate with the props. Ask a few pairs of real friends to choose a jungle-themed team name and come to the front for a face-off. Choose challenges from the options below, or make up your own! Give a prize to the friend duo with the most challenges completed in the time you've allotted.
 - **Banana Trust Walk:** Blindfold one friend and place a banana on their head. Their partner must guide them (using only words) to a different location in the room without dropping the banana. If the banana falls, the blindfolded friend has to find it using their friend's worded instructions.
 - **Coconut Roll:** Use a small ball or an actual coconut. One at a time, each friend attempts to roll it with their nose to a marked location and roll it back.
 - **Safari Snack Launch:** Use a plastic spoon to launch gummy worms or another soft candy into their partner's mouth or a cup strapped to their head. The partner catching can't move their feet.

QUESTION | Post-Game Press Conference

- **INSTRUCTIONS:** After the challenge, interview the friend pairs to see how they feel about their friendship now that they've lost or won.
 - On a scale from "besties" to "never speaking again," how's the friendship?
 - Do you think you could survive a real jungle together?



See the
Accessibility Hacks



QUESTION | What is a "good" friend?

- For the last few weeks, we've been talking about the kinds of friends we want to "stick with," in both good times and bad. You know, really good friends.
- But what is a "good" friend? Maybe it's someone who you can laugh with, vent with, and have fun with. Maybe it's someone who gets you, and always makes you feel understood. **What do you think? What is a "good" friend?**
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** Give a few students a chance to respond.

DISCUSSION

- **INSTRUCTIONS:** If you have more than 15 students, skip this discussion and save it for small groups. If you conduct this discussion, the starred questions are designed for high schoolers, so you may want to skip them for middle schoolers.
 - **If your life was an action-packed jungle adventure, who's a friend you'd want by your side and why?**
 - **What are the most important qualities to you in a "good" friend?**



See the Hacks



VIDEO | A Clip From *Jungle Cruise*

- "Good" friends of course exist, but no friendship is perfect. Not even the ones in the movies. Have you ever seen *Jungle Cruise*? If you're not familiar, here's the deal:
 - Frank, a fearless riverboat captain, ends up guiding Lily, a determined explorer, on a dangerous jungle expedition to uncover an ancient secret.
 - Here's how their friendship gets started...
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** As a teaching tool, play a short clip like [this one](#) (00:30–1:35) from *Jungle Cruise* where Frank fakes a fight with a jaguar. [Read this](#) for more information on legally using copyrighted material for educational purposes!
- Pretty impressive, right? Sure! Until you find out the whole fight was staged. That tiger? Yeah, it's basically Frank's (very large) pet cat. You can imagine how Lily might have felt when she discovered the whole fight was a scam.
- Maybe they didn't get off to a great start, but over time, Frank and Lily begin to trust each other and become pretty good friends! They learn to trust each other.
- But deception isn't exactly a great way to start a friendship, and it's definitely not a good way to maintain a friendship either. So later on, when Lily believes Frank is lying *again*, she loses it. She takes off, ready to complete their quest all on her own.



See the Middle
School Hacks



STORY | Talk about a time a good friend disappointed or upset you.

- **INSTRUCTIONS:** Tell a story (or ask a volunteer or student to tell a story) about a time a good friend did something to upset you. This could either be because they did something to hurt you and were in the wrong, or because you got upset with them but later realized you were the one who was wrong. Share why they were such a good friend, then share if you reconciled or if you only wish you'd reconciled.
- Sure, we had our disagreements and issues—what friendship doesn't? I've been there. You've been there. Frank and Lily have been there, too. On a cruise in the jungle, no less. (Oh, by the way, I should tell you—they do reconcile after Lily storms off, in case you were concerned.)

- Some friendships fade, but some friendships (the really good ones) are too valuable to throw away when things get tough. But sometimes...
 - It's hard to tell, when we're upset, if a friendship is really worth it or not.
 - We turn our back on good friendships too soon.
 - We don't know how to fix things when good friendships go wrong.
 - And we miss out on the kind of deep, strong, worthwhile friendships you only get by sticking it out when you think you want to walk away.
- Friendships can get complicated, tense, and difficult. So when do you know when to walk away and when to keep going?

SO WHAT? Why does it matter to God and to us?

DISCUSSION

- **INSTRUCTIONS:** *If you have more than 15 students, skip this discussion and save it for small groups. If you conduct this discussion, the starred questions are designed for high schoolers, so you may want to skip them for middle schoolers.*
 - **Do you think it's harder to find good friends or be a good friend? Why do you think so?**
 - *** If a good friend has ever disappointed or upset you, what did you do? How did that go?**

QUESTION | Good Friends Brainstorm

- A few minutes ago, we shared some quick ideas about what makes a good friend, but let's spend some more time on it. **What is a "good" friend?** Write down your ideas!
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** *Hand out [monstera-leaf-shaped note cards](#) or [faux monstera leaves](#), tape, and [permanent markers](#). Choose a place to display their cards, such as a wall, dry-erase board, window, or poster board. As students finish, fill the display with their ideas and read their responses. Leave the display in place to be used again next week. Ask questions to help them brainstorm, like...*
 - **What are good friends like?**
 - **What do good friends do?**
 - **What do good friends not do?**
 - **What would let you know a good friend is worth fighting for?**
- This is a great list! But if you're like me, and you're comparing your current friends to this list, maybe you're thinking things like...
 - "Aww, my friends are the best."
 - "Oops! Some of my friends I thought were great are maybe a little *less* good than I thought."
 - "Uhhh... if this is what it means to be a good friend, then I'm not sure I'm a good friend."
- It's not easy to find good friends or build good friendships, is it? And things get confusing when we find ourselves at odds with the friends we thought were good friends. We might be fighting with a friend because...
 - They upset us! (Even though we know they were probably right.)



See the High
School Hacks



- They hurt us, and we're not sure how to forgive them.
- We don't see eye-to-eye with them on something and we're not sure how to move forward.
- Or maybe we're not exactly *fighting* with a friend at the moment, but things have gotten awkward for some reason and we're not as close as we used to be.

SCRIPTURE | Proverbs 27:17

- It's hard to know how to handle conflicts with our friends. Thankfully, the book of Proverbs gives us tons of wisdom to help us. There are a lot of verses we could look at, but I'm going to read one verse I really love and ask what you think it means.
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** Read Proverbs 27:17. Ask, "**What do you think this means?**" and give a few students a chance to respond.
- If you've ever tried to use a dull knife to cut something, you know how hard it is.
 - Unless you're using it to spread butter, a dull knife is pretty annoying—not to mention dangerous. (Maybe that sounds weird, but Google it. Trying to cut stuff with dull knives can really mess you up.)
 - My point is, no one wants to be a dull knife. I know you don't, because you're here right now! You want to grow! You want to get better and sharper!
 - If you swipe two iron knives against each other with the right technique, both knives are going to get sharper. So if you're a knife, and you want to get sharper, you can't just spread butter all day. You're going to need to make contact with people who are made of the same stuff as you.
- So what does this Proverb mean? It means that the right friendships can help everyone in that friendship grow. But here's the thing about knife-sharpening: there's friction involved. In friendship, the friction you could face could be...
 - Conflict.
 - Disagreement.
 - Hurt feelings.
 - Misunderstanding.
 - Challenge.
- We've all faced those things in friendship. But when we do, it's worth asking...
 - Is this friend a "good" friend? Are we made of the same stuff?
 - How could this friction make us both sharper?
 - Does this person want to get sharper, or do they just want to fight? What about me?
- In friendship, disagreements and friction happen. Sometimes you're wrong. Sometimes they are. Sometimes you both are. But in godly friendships, disagreement doesn't have to separate you. It can actually make you both better—if you're willing to fight for each other, and not just against each other.

DISCUSSION

- **INSTRUCTIONS:** If you have more than 15 students, skip this discussion and save it for small groups. If you conduct this discussion, the starred questions are designed for high schoolers, so you may want to skip them for middle schoolers.

- What are some ways good friends can “sharpen” each other?
- * Who is one friend who “sharpens” you? How have you grown because of them?

SCRIPTURE | Acts 15:36–41

- Remember the friends we talked about in week one? Priscilla, Aquila, Apollos, and Paul were great examples of a good friend group. Through their friendship, they influenced each other for the better, and then influenced the whole world for Jesus, together.
- But of course, each of these friends had their own friends outside of that group. If you've ever had to navigate friends from different groups, you know it's not always easy to keep the peace.
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** Read Acts 15:36–41.
- Good friends don't always agree. Paul and Barnabas disagreed about whether or not they should bring another friend, John (also known as Mark), on their journey.
 - Paul had already decided he wasn't a fan because John had previously deserted them when they needed him.
 - The disagreement was so sharp, Paul and Barnabas decided to split up. Barnabas went with John in one direction and Paul went with a Silas in another direction.
 - For a while, they all kept doing great things for God, separately. We don't know all the details of what happened after that, but check out this letter Paul wrote a few years later...

SCRIPTURE | 2 Timothy 4:11

- **INSTRUCTIONS:** Read 2 Timothy 4:11.
- These guys were once in such a big fight that they went to completely different cities to get away from each other. But in the end, they reconciled. They decided their friendship, and the mission God had given them, was worth fighting for.
- Conflict, difficulty, and disagreement in healthy friendships can make you both better and wiser if you let God lead you through them. So when a friendship gets difficult, don't just give up. First, ask if God is trying to teach you both something, or help you both grow, through the difficulty. Because **good friends are worth fighting for**.

NOW WHAT? What does God want us to do about it?

DISCUSSION

- **INSTRUCTIONS:** If you have more than 15 students, skip this discussion and save it for small groups. If you conduct this discussion, the starred questions are designed for high schoolers, so you may want to skip them for middle schoolers.
 - * How would you decide if a friendship is worth fighting for or not?
 - What are some ways we can fight for our friendships when things are tense? What about when things are good?



See the Middle
School Hacks



Spend Time
With Others



REFLECTION | Growing Good

- We made this list together of what it means to be a "good" friend. But truly good friendships require both friends to be "good" friends.
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** *Invite everyone in your group to use the selfie side of a phone camera to look at themselves while they reflect. Then have them flip the camera and take a photo of the characteristics of a good friend that they want practice.*
- The friendships that sharpen you are worth fighting for. But are you the kind of friend who can sharpen others? Take a look at yourself in selfie mode. Now, try to imagine how some of your friends see you.
 - What goodness do they see when they're around you?
 - What areas of growth do they see?
 - Do they know you as someone who will fighting for them or give up?
 - Which of these characteristics of a "good" friend do you want to do a better job of practicing?
- If you're feeling discouraged or self-critical, let me encourage you: every knife needs sharpening sometimes. It doesn't mean you're broken or useless. It just means you have room to grow! That's exciting, because that's exactly what good friends help each other do.
- So next time you find yourself in some friction with a friend...
 - **PAUSE.** Don't panic! No friendship is without conflict. In fact, if you've never had conflict with a friend, your friendship may not be sharpening you as much as you'd like it to.
 - **REFLECT.** You've probably got a list of reasons why you're right and they're wrong, but have you tried looking at it from their perspective? How might you have gotten it wrong? What might you be able to learn from them? Is there something underneath the argument that matters more than what you're fighting about?
 - **ASK.** Ask God how you can learn and grow from the tension you're experiencing. Ask a wise person you trust to help you think through it.
 - **TRY.** You can't fix it all on your own, but you can take one tiny step to repair things—maybe a chat, a text, a change in your actions, or just a kind word to let them know you care! If this friendship is worth fighting for, don't quit too soon.

RESPONSE | You're Worth It Notes

- Sometimes, the best way to show a friend they matter is to *just say it*. So let's let those good friends know they're worth fighting for.
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** *Before your teaching time, print the [note cards](#) provided in your Week 3 folder. Set up a table with an assortment of note cards, pens, and whatever art supplies you've got hiding in the youth room closet. In addition to what's already printed on the cards, encourage students to add things to their notes like...*
 - Proverbs 27:17.
 - Specific ways they make you better.
 - A reminder you still care, even though you had a disagreement or things got a little messy.

- The "good" you see them.
- Thanks for seeing the "good" in you too.
- When you have a friend you know is worth it, make sure you stick together. Because **good friends are worth fighting for.**

DISCUSSION

- **INSTRUCTIONS:** *If you have more than 15 students, skip this discussion and save it for small groups. If you conduct this discussion, the starred questions are designed for high schoolers, so you may want to skip them for middle schoolers.*
 - **Read Psalm 51:10. When we've messed up or been in the wrong, what steps can we take to make things right with a friend?**
 - **This week, what's one way you're going to fight for a friendship that's worth it? What's one way you're asking God to help you become a better friend?**

MUSIC | "Count On Me" (Bruno Mars)

- As you leave, here's a song I'm dedicating to the good friends you have and the good friends you're becoming.
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** *Play the song "[Count On Me](#)" (Bruno Mars), or choose a song with similar themes from a Christian artist you like! But make sure you have purchased any licenses required to do so. For more information, [read this!](#) [Here's a link](#) to preview the song for your personal use.*